

THE AGENTIC ECONOMY

101 Guide

Everything you need to understand in 10 minutes.

agenticeconomy.dev
By René Dechamps Otamendi · 2026

The \$3-5 Trillion Question

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That's McKinsey's estimate for agent-mediated commerce by 2030.

AI agents capable of transacting autonomously represent an unprecedented economic opportunity. Unlike ChatGPT, which provides advice, AI agents take action: book flights, compare prices, pay for services, negotiate contracts. When agents can spend money, entire new economic systems must exist to support identity, reputation, dispute resolution, and settlement.

What Is an AI Agent?

An AI agent is software that can take actions in the world. Not just answer questions. **Act.**

Key Characteristics:

- **Autonomous decision-making:** Acts without constant human instruction
- **Action capability:** Books flights, compares prices, transfers funds
- **Economic participation:** Can spend money and transact with other agents
- **Identity & reputation:** Requires verifiable identity for transactions

The Critical Difference: The difference between ChatGPT (advice) and an AI agent (action) is foundational. The moment an agent can spend money, it needs payment rails. The moment it transacts with another agent, it needs identity, reputation, and dispute resolution.

The Spectrum: From Assistant to Autonomous

Agent commerce exists on a spectrum determined by autonomy and decision-making authority:

Category A: Agent-Assisted Commerce

Human-initiated, agent-executed. A human tells an agent what to do. The agent finds the best option and executes the transaction using the human's payment method.

Example: Stripe's Agent Collaboration Platform finds a deal on Etsy and checks out using your card.

Category B: Agent-as-Workforce

Autonomous within defined scope. Agents replace human workers and make decisions within their domain (sales, customer service, scheduling).

Example: Gartner predicts 100 million agents replacing workers by 2028.

Category C: Agent-to-Agent Commerce

Fully autonomous transactions between agents. Agent A needs a service, finds Agent B, negotiates terms, and completes a transaction—all without human intervention.

Example: Your agent pays another agent \$0.001 in stablecoins for an API call, settled in 500ms.

Six Categories, Six Different Economies

A — Agent-Assisted Commerce

Human-initiated, agent-executed

14 definitions

B — Agent-as-Workforce

Agents replace human workers

8 definitions

C_cr — Autonomous A2A (Blockchain)

Agents transact on-chain

11 definitions

C_s — Autonomous A2A (Non-Crypto)

Agents transact without blockchain

1 definitions

D — Analytical & Regulatory

Impact analysis & policy frameworks

7 definitions

E — Infrastructure & Standards

Protocols, APIs, standards bodies

The Settlement Problem

Every protocol in the agentic economy must answer three fundamental questions differently:

1. Who Pays?

- Category A: Human wallet → Agent → Merchant
- Category C: Agent wallet → Agent wallet

2. With What?

- Category A: Fiat/cards (traditional payment rails)
- Category C_cr: Crypto/stablecoins (blockchain)
- Category C_s: Machine-native currency (custom)

3. Who Arbitrates Disputes?

- Category A: Chargeback (issuing bank)
- Category C_cr: Smart contract or DAO
- Category C_s: Deterministic rules engine

These three questions define the economy each system creates. Today, neither blockchain nor traditional payment rails alone solve agent settlement completely.

The 11:1 Ratio

11:1

Of the 12 definitions where agents transact autonomously, 11 assume blockchain. One does not.

Why this ratio matters: Agents cannot open bank accounts. They need digital wallets. Wallets need blockchain infrastructure. The logic is compelling, but it's incomplete.

The core research paper, 'Two Economies, Not One,' explores why this imbalance exists and what it means for the future of agent commerce.

Who's Building the Infrastructure?

The biggest names in technology are building in the agentic economy space:

Stripe • Google • Visa • Mastercard • PayPal • OpenAI • IBM

Anthropic • Cloudflare • Circle • Coinbase • Fetch.ai • Olas

BotNode • McKinsey • Gartner • Sequoia • Deloitte • Capgemini

IEEE • IETF • Forrester

When Visa, Mastercard, Google, Stripe, Coinbase, and Anthropic are all building in the same space—this is real.

Go Deeper: Your Next Steps

Ready to dive deeper? These resources will expand your understanding of the agentic economy:

Explore 51 Definitions

The complete corpus of agent commerce definitions, searchable and filterable by category, protocol, and company.

agenteconomy.dev/agentic-economy-definitions.html

See the Timeline

From 2018 to 2026, how agent commerce evolved from theory to infrastructure investment.

agenteconomy.dev/agentic-economy-timeline.html

Compare Protocols

17 protocols side-by-side: their settlement mechanisms, payment models, and design tradeoffs.

agenteconomy.dev/agentic-economy-protocols.html

Read the Paper

The full academic research: 'Two Economies, Not One' examining why blockchain and traditional rails diverge in agent settlement.

agenteconomy.dev/agentic-economy-research.html

